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Marxism: The Celebrity of Capitalist Critique

In contemporary dialogues surrounding American politics and critiques of capitalism, the ideas of Karl Marx seem to be the most frequently discussed. Thinking back to the 2020 US presidential election, Bernie Sanders was often called a Marxist for, what much right-wing media called, his so-called socialist, communist, and anti-capitalist politics. Rarely do you hear people who critique capitalism being called followers of Weberianism or “Engelsists”. Why is Marx the foremost sociologist and philosopher for contemporary anti-capitalists to reference and identify with? Ultimately, it is Marx’s method of sociology, writing to inspire change rather than only interpreting history as Weber did, that makes his critique of capitalism the more prominent theory for contemporary anti-capitalists to identify with.

By offering only critique, Weber is more likely to instill a sense of nihilism or skepticism rather than inspiration or hope for change and progress in his readers. Weber’s writing in *The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism* studies the creation of the capitalistic spirit and also discusses the consequences of this spirit. Specifically, in Chapter 5, “Asceticism and the Spirit of Capitalism”, Weber explains that society’s value on material goods, instilled by the spirit of capitalism, is an “iron cage” (Weber, 123). This imagery of the entrapment or imprisonment of people in the modern capitalist system has a negative connotation and shows that Weber is critical of capitalism. Weber discusses the effects that this “iron cage” has on individuals in society, such as a departure from values and tradition dictating social action, but never prescribes

remedies or alternatives to the negative effects of capitalism. This leaves readers to believe that capitalism's prison and all its effects are immutable and inescapable. Ultimately, Weber was identifying the means that created the end, modern capitalist society, implying that there is no future outside of capitalism that society can shift to. Although Weber is using connotatively negative language that could make readers skeptical of the advantageousness of capitalism, the idea of an unchangeable world could reasonably plant a sense of nihilism in followers of Weber. While active nihilism, a concept introduced by Nietzsche, can create hope and push us to change, Weber believes there are no alternative political or social systems to work towards when living under capitalism. If contemporary anti-capitalists were to identify with Weber, their movement would only aim to inspire discontent toward capitalism. Their ideology would have little to no potential impact on the way our world functions.

Marx's dialectical model of social analysis caused his written works to inspire the contemplation of and action toward new social systems within his readers. One major difference between the works of Marx and Weber is Marx's introduction of communism in his *Manifesto of the Communist Party*. Weber, in *The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism*, is interested in exposing the origins of human behaviors, specifically how the emergence of modern capitalism was aided by ascetic Protestantism, and the consequences modern capitalism has on social life, like his concept of the iron cage of rationality. While Marx also traces the origins and consequences of the modern capitalist system, he doesn't just leave his readers with discontent towards the capitalist system they are living in; as Marx introduces, and praises, communism as the inevitable end to capitalism, he gives readers ground to believe that the end to capitalism and institution of communism is favorable for the wellbeing of society. This arises from Marx's belief in the dialectical method. Dialectics emphasize the two-sidedness of everything, and it was

Marx's dialectical reflections and critiques of capitalism that created the theory of communism. The negatives of capitalism are accompanied by the positives of communism allowing readers to believe that the negatives of their current system can be replaced and improved by a new system. The inclusion of the *Manifesto of the Communist Party* generates a sense of hope for the betterment of society which more easily impassions readers of Marx, rather than readers of Weber, to take steps to achieve an alternative to the current system he just condemned.

Not only is Marx's ideology adoptable because of its dialectical nature, but also because it is based on Marx's belief that philosophy and sociology are means for change. Marx's *Theses on Feuerbach* touches on the importance of change and action in philosophy and sociology: "Philosophers have hitherto only *interpreted* the world in various ways; the point is to *change* it" (Marx, *Theses on Feuerbach*, 1888). Today, communities of people who share the same ideology are often characterized by the desire to take certain actions or steps to implement their ideology into society. Someone who reads Weber's concept of the iron cage may end up believing that capitalism imprisons them, but this ideology does not necessarily drive action to change society or inspire readers to value a system other than capitalism. Therefore, people who believe Weberian ideology lack values that create action toward a theoretically achievable goal for society, making it harder for Weberians to become a prominent, socially impactful, ideological community. Marx, on the other hand, prescribes communism as the end of capitalism by means of revolution. Followers of Marx could theoretically take action towards a revolution to dismantle capitalism. What that revolution looks like may not necessarily align with what Marx imagined it would look like, but Marx's idea of a revolution from the working class persists. Furthermore, part of Marx's desired audience was industrial workers, workers whom he believed would inevitably enact a revolution against capitalism. By writing for this audience, Marx aimed

to bring the problems of capitalism to the forefront of workers' consciousness which would, in turn, lead to the proletariat's realization of their working conditions and, ultimately, inspire their revolution. In this way, Marx's work not only addresses communism as an alternative to capitalism but also begins the work towards enacting the revolution; it's almost as if he is causing the inevitable change he predicts.

Given Marx's dialectic approach to sociology and his belief that ideas should change the world, his writing lends itself ground to be embraced by anti-capitalists that desire a change in the system they live in. Weber's interpretation of history to explain the capitalist spirit is a capitalist critique harder for modern anti-capitalist to congregate around because it lacks the power to inspire people to alter the existing state of society. Today, in the United States, we see how important ideological similarity within government or political parties is for progress and change; it is clear that Marx's ideology, backed by his frequent citation of the term "proletariat", was written to inspire a widespread ideological revolution. One could argue that the increasing interest in Marxism in contemporary society and media means Marx has somewhat succeeded.

Works Cited

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